



Pollinators



This day-flying moth uses its strawlike mouthpart—which is about as long as its body—to drink nectar from flowers of many shapes and sizes.

Hummingbird hawk-moth

The long beak reaches into the flower, and the bird's head is dusted with pollen.

Violet sabrewing hummingbird

The tiny wings of the hummingbird can flap many times in a second, allowing the bird to hover in one place as it feeds.

The waxy bract of the banana flower bud curves back to give birds easy access to the flower inside.

Bumblebee

Bell-shaped, yellow flowers remain closed unless forced open by a pollinator.

The possum's excellent climbing skills help it run up and down flowering trees.

Pygmy possum

Ladybug

Beetle-pollinated flowers make a lot of pollen that stick to these clumsy insects.

As the bumblebee opens up the flower and scrambles inside to get to the nectar, its fuzzy hairs collect pollen.

This eucalyptus tree flowers in winter, relying on mammals for pollination at a time when insects are scarce.

Although insects are the most common pollinators, larger animals such as birds and bats also play a vital role in pollination. In return, plants provide sweet nectar. Different flower shapes, colors, and smells attract specific pollinators.

Bees and butterflies visit fragrant, brightly colored flowers, which grow in clusters or have large petals for the insects to land on. Many moths prefer white or very pale flowers that open at night, following their sweet floral scents to find them in the dark. Beetles, such